an audio or videocassette of a Bollywood film. Besides that, quite often, the people would ask me, ‘Are you from India?’ When I nodded, they would effusively continue, ‘Le pays de Gandhi! Quel grand homme et quel magnifique pays!’ (The country of Gandhi! What a great man and what a magnificent country!) This is indeed a true reflection of India’s soft power.

At the end of my stay of three years in Algeria, I received orders to take over 79 Mountain Brigade on promotion to the rank of brigadier. This brigade was in the Kashmir valley. Our son had already joined the university in Le Havre, a port town near the coast of Normandy, to do a masters programme in commerce. And our daughter had returned to India a little earlier, to join the Army Public School in Delhi. We flew back to India after a few days’ stay at London and Paris, where our military attaché, Brigadier (later lieutenant general) Raj Kadyan, and his wife, Anita, hosted us warmly.

Towards the end of our stay in Algeria, we saw changes taking place in its society. People were getting under the influence of fundamentalists and new mosques were being built with funds reportedly coming from Saudi Arabia and other sources. One day our daughter’s Algerian friend told her that she couldn’t move out of her house anymore without wearing a hijab (head scarf) and that she would have to be escorted by her brother. Soon after we left in December 1990, Algeria went through a vicious cycle of religious extremism and terrorism. The situation became so bad that for some time we had to close down our mission in Algiers. All the hard work done by us to build bridges and enhance cooperation in the political, diplomatic and military fields was undone.